



Ad-support labels

Apps on the Play store that support internal advertisements will be clearly labelled by Jan 2016 <http://dgit.in/AdSprtApps>



Sentiri, the smart headband

Sentiri is a proximity-sensing headband that helps steer users around by motor-driven haptic feedback on object detection: <http://dgit.in/Sentiri>

Feature

the basic functionality of OTT services. Certain telecom majors have been trying to push the logic that they are similar to Highway corporations in the way they function. According to them, just like Highway corporations receive tolls for maintaining the Highway, they too deserve some form of regular monetary compensation from OTT content providers. The only and perhaps the sufficient reason why that is absurd is that they already do receive regular monetary compensation for maintaining those highways of data: Internet Bills!

A company like Bharti Airtel, one of the earliest proponents of regulating OTT services, had posted a rise in profit by 30% from Data usage as per reports in April 2015. This is the same provider that tried to bring in separate internet usage plans for VoIP services in December over concerns of lost revenue.

Hence it was no surprise, that when TRAI tried to discuss Regulatory Framework for Over-the-Top Services over an open forum, it got over a million responses in spite of a short deadline. The email address releasing debacle that followed was highly unfortunate and irresponsible on the part of TRAI, but the netizens of India had made their stand on net neutrality as clear as daylight. After all, it is only because the internet is neutral that applications like Whatsapp, YouTube, and Skype could become so good at what they do. And for more of them to come by, be developed and used, OTT services have to stay unaffected.

Free Internet or the Free Internet?

Zero has always been a too-good-to-be-true number to show up on bills of any kind. So when Airtel launched the Airtel Zero platform in April 2015, the internet smelt something fishy and was up in arms in no time. The fact that it came right after the whole TRAI-OTT issue did not help its cause either.

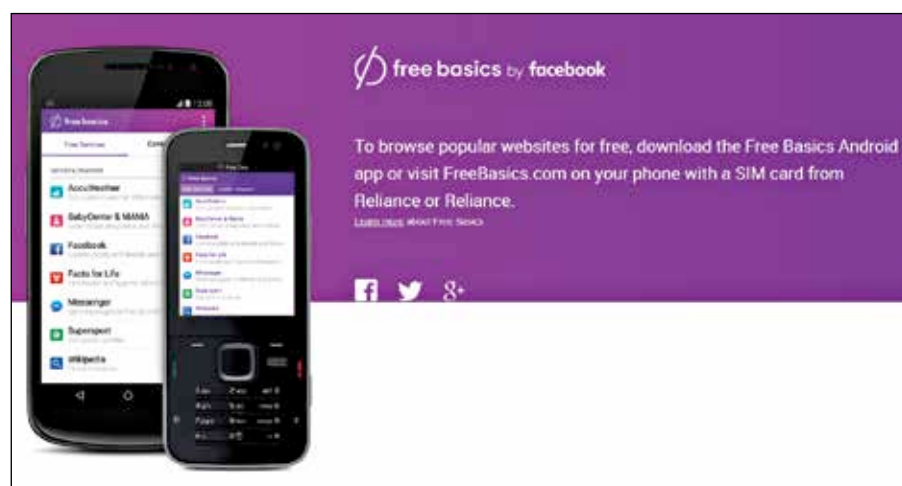
Zero Rating is a scheme under which Mobile Network providers and ISPs do not charge the customer for data used to access certain specific websites or applications. For a developing country like ours, Internet is a very strong tool

to put growth on the fast lane. From the advent of the Internet into homes to the comparatively recent smart-phone revolution, the economy of any sector has improved due to connectivity and the easy availability of information. In spite of that, when a financially deprived citizen wants to use the internet, one of his most prominent hurdles is the cost. Facing the choice between spending money on basic necessities or the internet, it is evident why less than one fifth of the population is connected. Until the gap between the cost and the need for connectivity is bridged, it is unlikely that Internet will

Free Basics

Internet.org, Facebook CEO Mark Zuckerberg's brainchild, was launched in August 2013 with the goal of achieving a connected world. His vision was to bring basic internet connectivity to the less developed parts of the world in the form of affordable access. Similar to Airtel Zero, it is a platform centred on the idea of providing certain services like News, Weather Forecast, Messaging and more to the user without any data cost.

The intentions are clear: to get a vast majority of the Indian populace online, empowering them to achieve more. But



Noble endeavour or insidious scheme?

be used to its full potential in India. This is where Airtel decided to give it a shot.

Airtel Zero is a platform based on zero rating where Airtel customers can access certain apps or parts of apps and websites for free. The app developer or company pays for the data consumption on their app and the customer is still free to access other apps or websites by paying for the data being used to access them.

This gives the impression that Airtel is trying to create a separate island of privileged content providers who have the required bank balances to compensate Airtel's bandwidth costs. The start-ups which rely heavily on popularity for their success would now face another formidable barrier to compete with big and established competition. For obvious reasons and severe backlash, Flipkart, one of the most prominent companies to show interest in this, took a step back and exited the platform.

it is undeniable that this concept treads on the neutrality of the internet. Providing selective free access, even with the noblest of intentions, to a population of this size indicates a strong advantage for the provider. It does raise the question that if Orkut could have done the same, would we even have a Facebook today?

Launched in India in February this year, Facebook's timing was unfortunate to say the least. Even if there was any promise to be seen at the onset, it was promptly drowned in a barrage of net neutrality related accusations. The biggest point in question is Facebook's tie up with Reliance Communications providing exclusive access to the platform on their network. Any form of free access over a mobile network certainly attracts more users to the network compared to other networks which charge the users for the same services. Perhaps Facebook's initia-